

RESTORATION / 2018 / SPRINGFIELD, IL

Illinois State Capitol Handrails

Office of the Architect of the Capitol



Nineteenth century iron handrails on the fourth floor gallery, restored and brought to ADA compliance without losing their period character.

THE WORK

The fourth floor gallery outside the Illinois House of Representatives is lined with nineteenth century cast iron handrails, most likely bought from a Sears catalog around 1880 to 1890. Over the decades they had been painted and repainted to look like bronze, then gold, then back again. The job was to return them to what they were, and to make them safe for the people who use the building now.

THE MATERIAL QUESTION

Restoration means matching what already exists, and much of it was missing. The railing also had to reach ADA height and gain a toe kick, so nothing is kicked from the fourth floor onto the third, without the additions reading as a violation of the original.

THE MAKING

We removed the components and stripped them back to bare iron. The railing is modular and its sections repeat, so a detail missing in one panel could almost always be found in another; we molded just that portion and cast the replacements, alongside match plate sand patterns and lost wax reproductions patinated to match. The original top rail had itself been wood, in very poor condition. We replaced it with a cap milled to the same profile used throughout the Capitol, which gave the height ADA required.

IN PLACE

For Ben Stagl it was one of the biggest honors of his life. The Architect of the Capitol took him inside the walls and up into the cupola, where they came out at the top with a direct line of sight to Lincoln's tomb. Then he handed Ben a Sharpie and let him sign the inside of the cupola, alongside others who have worked on the building.

DETAILS

Year

2018

Location

Springfield, IL

Category

Restoration

Materials

Cast iron, bronze, milled hardwood

CREDITS

Office of the Architect of the Capitol

CJP Architects

Imperial Woodworking

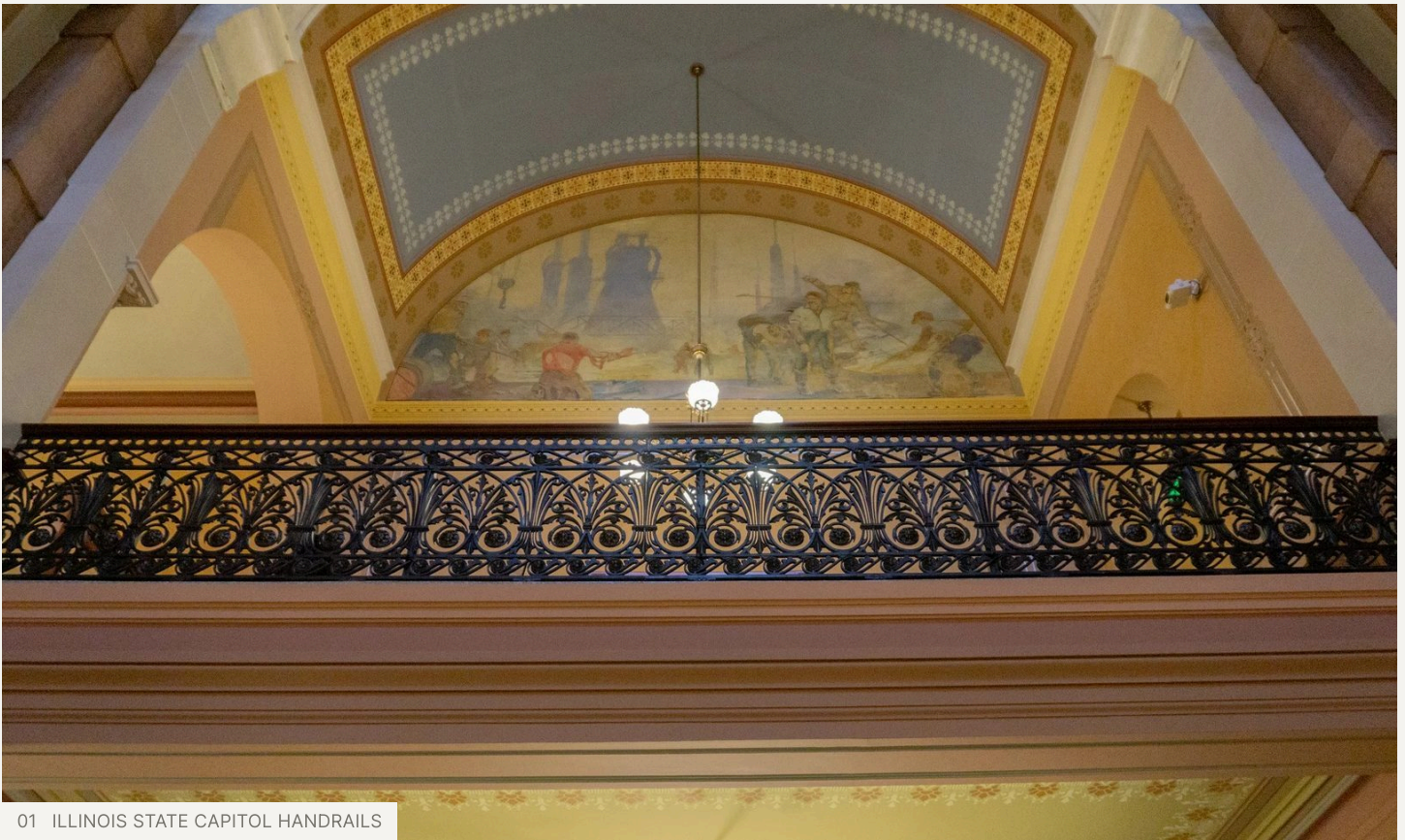
Chicago Crucible

STUDIO

ChiLab Studio

Chicago, Illinois

Established 2013



01 ILLINOIS STATE CAPITOL HANDRAILS



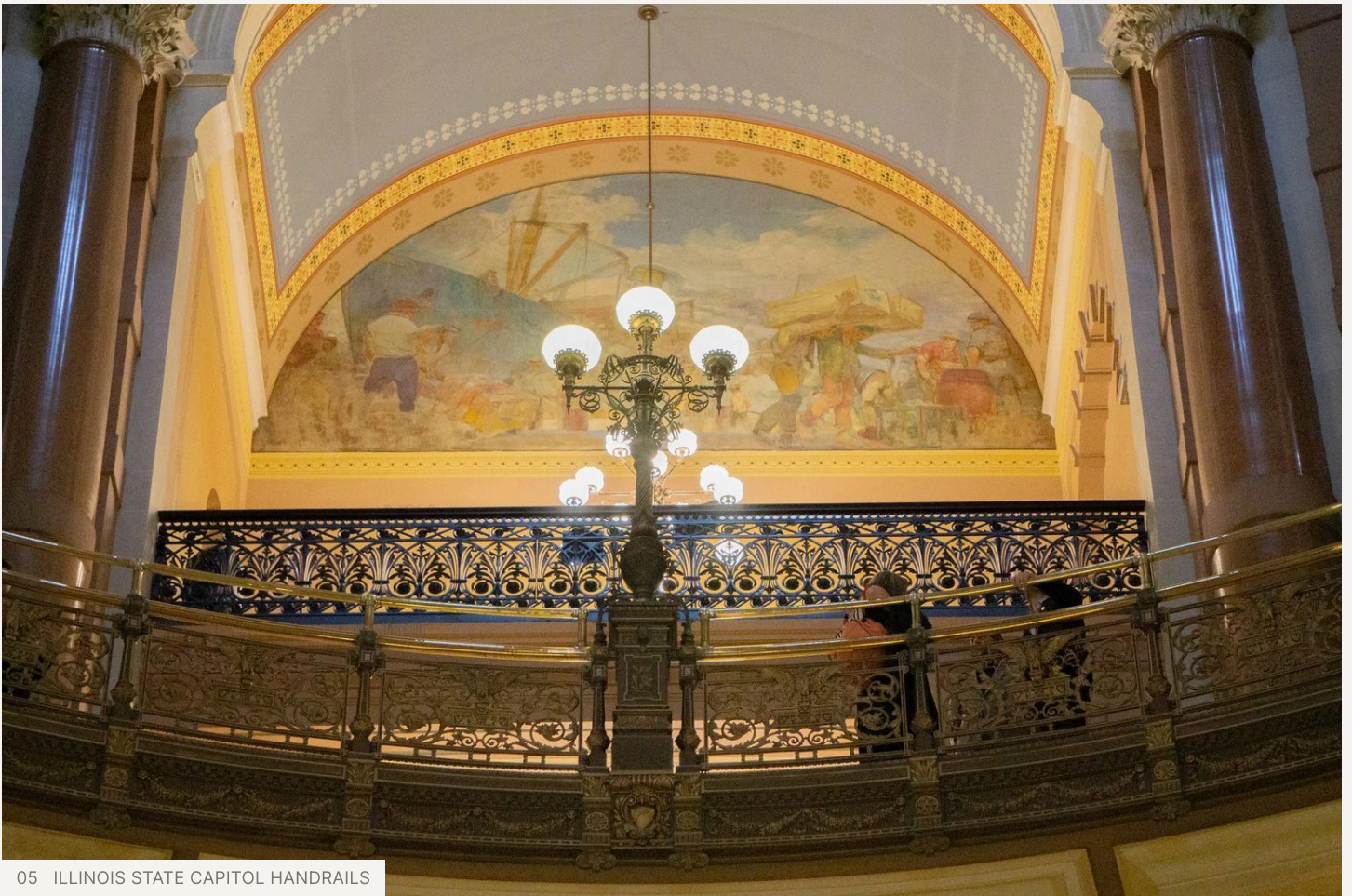
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03 ILLINOIS STATE CAPITOL HANDRAILS



04 ILLINOIS STATE CAPITOL HANDRAILS



05 ILLINOIS STATE CAPITOL HANDRAILS

Bring us a drawing, a model, or a hunch.

THE STUDIO

Specialty material projects for architecture, interior design, public art, and the fine arts.

ChiLab Studio, Chicago, Illinois. Established 2013.

WHAT WE DO

Metal casting

Glass

Finishes

Digital fabrication

Metal fabrication

Restoration

Project management

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